

Clockwise from left: 13-day aged duck breast, kadubu, fresh bamboo shoots, puli chikku at Farmlore; Salted Duck Breast, Hyderabadi Sesame Tamarind Sauce, pickled root vegetables at The Cinnamon Club; Petit Fours Based on Festivals of India at The Bungalow, New York; Thayir Sadam—Beetroot , goat cheese, sisho at Papa's Mumbai; Askalu at Naar

CONCEPT RESTAURANTS

FARM TO TABLE

As concepts go, Farmlore in Bengaluru, flips the script. Set inside a working farm, the experience begins the moment you enter its gates. "Here, 'farm-to-table' isn't a slogan, it's a way of life. Unaffected by lengthy transit durations, each ingredient radiates freshness. The plates, crafted by artisans such as Adil Writer and Mabbu Studios, are stunning, but they're just the stage. The real drama? The food. Flavours are precise and powerful, transforming humble produce into unforgettable moments. At Farmlore, taste is the heart of it, leaving you craving more long after", shares Chef Owner Johnson Ebenezer.

DESTINATION DINING

"Taste comes from memory, intuition, and restraint. At Naar, we don't start with 'what's the story?' We start with 'would you crave this again tomorrow?' If the answer is no, nothing else matters", add Sadhu. For Chef Manish Mehrotra of Nisaba, this translates to chaat; a dish bursting with flavour, texture, and controlled chaos. He describes chaat as "organized chaos," where spice, crunch, sweetness, and tang come together perfectly. For him, taste is everything. "Taste is supreme, flavours are king," he says. Forget fancy plating, what matters is making guests come back, driven by unforgettable flavours. Like chaat, his cooking is lively, balanced, and straight from the heart, a dish you try once and crave forever.

CHEF'S TABLE

Cooking is more than simply a talent, it's an alchemy of hands and heart—a language expressed via flavour and flame. That's the secret ingredient, the pulse behind a truly great chef. At the helm of the exclusive 12-seat, high-energy "chef's counter", Papa's, Chef Hussain Shahzad says, "Monotony is part of the craft. If anything, it keeps you grounded. We are lucky to host just 12 people, four nights a week, and do it on our own terms. So every night feels different. The energy in the room keeps changing. The focus is to stay consistent with the experience, not with a fixed script. The conversations, the jokes, the banter all have to feel natural. The moment it feels forced, it can get boring. We also constantly change our dishes and the way we serve them."

If a 13-course irreverent menu, with evenings that resemble a culinary pantomime, decodes the popularity index at Papa's, according to Saini, the finest Wok lessons are imbibed by working alongside someone you admire: "I have always looked up to Chef Manish Mehrotra, both in and out of the kitchen. He's my first and only mentor, and his influence on me goes far beyond recipes and techniques. In the kitchen, he taught me how to respect ingredients and reimagine Indian cuisine without losing its soul," shares the 3 Michelin wonder chef. Learn with humility, cook with soul. That's the magic.